

M2T2: Managing Sugar Cravings — 9 min

Video File M2T2-Sugar.mp4 · **Resources** Sugar Swap Recipes.pdf (swaps, craving-buster tea, mood & energy tracker)
· **Xp** 90 total · Try 1 Swap 40 · Track Mood & Energy 30 · Share in Forum 20

Target runtime 9 min · 1,167 spoken words · ≈ 7.8 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 8.6 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 HOOK

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera. On the counter: a can of soda, a chocolate bar, and beside them a bowl of berries with walnuts and a steaming mug.]

For most of my adult life, three o'clock in the afternoon owned me. Not the whole day, just that one hour, when I'd find myself standing in front of whatever was sweet and telling myself it was the last time. It was never the last time, until I understood what was actually happening at three o'clock. Today I'm going to show you what I learned, and give you the swaps that finally made that hour mine again.

0:30–3:30 HOW SUGAR AFFECTS FERTILITY

[VISUAL: Animation: blood-sugar curve spikes after a sweet drink, then crashes; insulin rises; an ovary icon dims.]

Let's connect the dots from Module One. When you drink something sweet on an empty stomach, blood sugar rises fast, insulin rises to match, and two hours later you're lower than where you started. In Module One we saw the brain side of

that crash. Here's the ovary side. In the Nurses' Health Study, Jorge Chavarro's team found that women whose diets had a higher glycemic load, more fast-digesting carbohydrate, had a higher risk of ovulatory infertility, published in the European Journal of Clinical Nutrition. And a meta-analysis in Diabetes Care by Vasanti Malik and colleagues linked regular sugar-sweetened beverages to insulin resistance, metabolic syndrome, and type two diabetes, the same insulin problem that disrupts ovulation.

For men, the story runs through the same channel. Salas-Huetos and colleagues, reviewing dozens of studies in Human Reproduction Update, found that diets high in sugar-sweetened drinks and processed foods were associated with poorer semen quality. And you'll remember the study in Epidemiology of nearly four thousand couples: one or more sugary drinks a day, about twenty percent lower monthly fecundability, for both partners.

[VISUAL: Slide: "The stress-sugar loop": stress → cortisol → sugar craving → crash → stress.]

Now the loop that keeps it all going. Stress raises cortisol. Cortisol, as Adam and Epel showed in Physiology and Behavior, increases the drive for sugar and fat. The sugar

spikes and crashes, and a crashing blood sugar is itself a stressor: your body releases adrenaline and cortisol to bring it back up. So stress drives sugar, and sugar drives stress. This is why "just use willpower" fails. You're not fighting a habit. You're fighting a loop, and the only way to beat a loop is to interrupt it somewhere.

One more piece of good news before the swaps. A craving is a wave, not a wall. Researchers in addiction psychology, including Sarah Bowen and Alan Marlatt in the journal *Psychology of Addictive Behaviors*, describe a practice called urge surfing: noticing a craving rise, crest, and fall without acting on it. Most urges peak and pass within about twenty minutes. Everything I'm about to give you is designed to help you ride that twenty minutes rather than fight it.

3:30–7:30 HEALTHY SWAPS: INTERRUPTING THE LOOP

[VISUAL: Slide: "Swap 1: sweet plus protein plus fat."]

Swap one: never eat sweet alone. Berries with a handful of walnuts instead of candy. A square of eighty-five percent dark chocolate with almonds instead of a milk chocolate bar. Apple slices with nut butter. The protein and fat slow the sugar

down, so there's no spike and no crash to chase. This is the single most useful swap in this entire module.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Swap 2: protein-first breakfast."]

Swap two: start the day with protein. Eggs, Greek yogurt, the smoothie from Training One, leftover salmon, beans. A protein-first breakfast steadies blood sugar for hours, and in my experience the three o'clock craving is very often a bill for a breakfast of toast and jam. Move the protein to the morning and watch what happens to the afternoon.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Swap 3: the fifteen-minute walk."]

Swap three: walk before you decide. Researchers at the University of Exeter found that a brisk fifteen-minute walk reduced cravings and snacking on chocolate in regular chocolate eaters, published in the journal *Appetite*. The walk moves the blood sugar, burns off the adrenaline, and, most importantly, changes the scenery. You'll meet this again in Module Three.

[DEMO: Cynthia makes her craving-buster tea: a mug, a cinnamon stick, fresh ginger, a splash of vanilla, hot water; optional rooibos teabag.]

And swap four, my favorite: the craving-buster tea. Hot water, a cinnamon stick, three or four slices of fresh ginger, a drop of

pure vanilla, and if you like, a rooibos teabag, which is naturally caffeine-free and slightly sweet. Let it steep five minutes. Cinnamon and vanilla give your senses the sweetness they're asking for, ginger settles the stomach, and the warmth itself is soothing. Here's what people I've worked with tell me matters most: the ritual. Making the tea takes four minutes, and four minutes is longer than most cravings last. You're not resisting. You're waiting, with a warm mug in your hands.

One safety note: skip licorice-root teas while you're trying to conceive or pregnant; they can affect blood pressure and hormones. Cinnamon, ginger, peppermint, rooibos, and chamomile are gentle choices, and if you have any medical condition, check with your doctor about herbal teas.

A quick word on artificial sweeteners, because people often swap sugar for diet soda and wonder why the cravings stay. The research on sweeteners is mixed and still evolving, but one thing is consistent: intensely sweet tastes keep the sweet expectation alive, and they don't give you the protein, fat, or fiber that quiets the loop. I'd rather you have berries and

walnuts than a diet soda, and I'd rather you have the tea than either.

And a word for couples. Sugar is a shared environment. If one partner keeps a drawer of candy at home, the other partner's swaps are fighting the drawer every evening. You don't have to police each other, but it's fair to ask for one thing: keep the sweet stuff out of sight, on a high shelf or in the car, not on the counter. Out of sight is out of the loop.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Emotional eating: revisit Module 1, Training 2 and 3."]

Now, the emotional bucket. Some cravings are not about blood sugar at all; they're about the hour after the hard conversation, or the quiet after everyone is asleep. For those, the swap isn't a food. It's a two-minute pause with your hand on your heart, the way we practiced in Training Three, and a question: what do I actually need right now? Rest, comfort, company, a good cry? Sugar is the fastest answer and the worst one. Grace over guilt applies here more than anywhere. If you eat the thing, you learned something. Write it in the tracker and move on.

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

Two tips before you go. First, don't swap everything at once; pick the one that matches your strongest trigger from Module One. Physiological trigger, protein-first breakfast.

Environmental, rearrange the kitchen so the berries are at eye level and the chocolate isn't. Emotional, the tea and the pause. Second, track your mood and energy for a week, not your weight, not your calories. Energy at three p.m., mood at nine p.m. Those two numbers will tell you more about what's working than any scale.

I'm not going to tell you sugar is evil. I'm going to tell you that you deserve to own your afternoons again, and that every steady afternoon is a steadier hormone environment for the family you're growing.

[VISUAL: End card: "Sugar Swap Recipes PDF → Try 1 swap (40 XP) → Track mood & energy (30 XP) → Share in the forum (20 XP)."]

Download the Sugar Swap Recipes PDF. Try one swap this week for forty XP, track your mood and energy on the page inside for thirty, and share which swap you picked in the

forum for twenty. Next, Training Three: hydration, and the honest truth about detox drinks.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Sugar Swap Recipes.pdf (swaps by trigger, craving-buster tea, 7-day mood & energy tracker). **ACTION 1:** Try one swap this week (40 XP). **ACTION 2:** Track mood and energy for 7 days (30 XP). **ACTION 3:** Share your swap in the forum (20 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 3 · Hydration and Detox Drinks.